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THE BOY WHO TALKED TO THE STARS



*A bedtime story about a mind that works a little differently — and
a world that needs exactly that.*

BY MK PARRISH • \$14

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A NOTE BEFORE THE STORY

Some children see the world the way most people do.

And some children see it sideways, or upside down, or in colors nobody else noticed were there. They line their toys up in careful rows. They know every fact about one enormous thing. They cover their ears when the room gets loud, and they light up like a whole city when they find the one person who understands.

This is a story for those children — and for everyone who loves one. It is about a boy named Theo, who could not always find the right words, but who could hear something the rest of the kingdom had stopped listening to.

Read it slowly. And when it ends, tell the child beside you the truest thing in it: *the way your mind works is not a mistake. It is a gift the world has not learned to hold yet.*

THE BOY WHO TALKED TO THE STARS

In a kingdom at the edge of the sea, there lived a boy named Theo who did not do things the way the other children did.

When the other children played their loud, tangled games in the square, Theo sat at the edge and arranged his stones — smallest to largest, dark to light, in a line so straight it could have been drawn with a ruler. When the market grew crowded and clanging, Theo pressed his hands over his ears and squeezed his eyes shut until the noise stopped climbing up his skin. And when someone asked him a question too quickly, the words he wanted got stuck somewhere behind his teeth, and he could only look at his shoes.

"He's a strange one," the townspeople whispered, not unkindly, but not kindly either. "Off in his own world."

They were right about one thing. Theo did have a world. It was only that nobody had thought to ask him what was in it.

Because here is what the townspeople did not know: every night, when the kingdom went dark and quiet and the terrible noise finally stopped, Theo climbed to the top of the hill behind his house and looked up. And the stars — the stars talked to him.

Not in words. Theo did not always trust words; they were slippery things that changed their meaning and came too fast. The stars spoke in patterns. In the slow, exact turning of the sky. Theo knew them all — every point of light, where it rose, where it set, which ones traveled together and which ones stood alone. He knew the sky the way the other children knew each other's faces. It never got too loud. It never asked him to hurry. It simply turned, and turned, and let him watch.

"Hello," Theo would say to the stars, and the words came out smooth as anything, because the stars were never in a rush for an answer. "You're early tonight."

And the sky would wheel above him, patient and enormous, and Theo would feel the thing he almost never felt down in the noisy town: he would feel like he fit.

One autumn, a trouble came to the kingdom.

The fishing boats began to go out and not come back on time. A fog would roll in off the sea, thick and grey and sudden, and the fishermen, who steered by the coastline, would lose the shore entirely and drift, frightened, until it lifted. Two boats had run onto the rocks. The whole town was afraid.

The mayor called everyone to the square. "We need a way to find our way home in the fog," she said. "A way that doesn't depend on seeing the land."

The clever adults argued. They suggested bigger lanterns, and louder bells, and longer ropes, and none of it would work in a fog you could not see or hear through. The square got louder and louder, everyone talking over everyone, and Theo sat at the edge with his hands over his ears, rocking a little, waiting for it to stop.

But he was listening. Theo was always listening, even when it looked like he was somewhere else.

And when there was the smallest gap in the noise, Theo stood up. His heart was pounding. The words wanted to stick behind his teeth. But this was too important, so he pushed them out, one at a time, the way he pushed his stones into a line.

"The stars," said Theo.

The whole square turned to look at him. He wanted to disappear. He made himself keep going.

"The fog is low," he said. "It sits on the water. But it is thin at the top. If you look straight up — the stars come through. And the stars don't move like the land moves. They come back to the same place, every night, exactly. I know where they all are. I could — I could teach the fishermen to steer by them. So when they can't see the shore, they look up. And the sky brings them home."

For a moment, nobody said anything.

Then the oldest fisherman, a man with a face like a cracked map, said quietly, "The boy's right. Sailors used to do it, long ago. We forgot. We got used to steering by the land." He looked at Theo with something new in his eyes. "But nobody in this town remembers the stars well enough to teach it."

"I do," said Theo.

And he did.

All that winter, Theo stood on the hill with the fishermen gathered around him, and he taught them the sky. He was patient in a way none of them expected, because the sky had taught him patience first. He never got flustered. He never rushed. He drew the patterns in the dirt with a stick, smallest to largest, dark to light, in lines so straight they could have been drawn with a ruler — and for the first time, the whole town was grateful for exactly the way Theo's mind worked.

When the fog came now, the fishermen tipped their heads back and found Theo's stars, and the sky brought every last boat home.

The children in the square still played their loud, tangled games. Theo still sat at the edge, most days, arranging his stones. That did not change, and it did not need to. But something else changed. Now, when a child got lost on the way home, or scared, or turned around in the dark, the grown-ups would say, "Go find Theo. Theo knows the way things are supposed to line up."

And a few of the braver children began to sit beside him at the edge of the square — not to pull him into their game, but to learn his. To line up stones. To go quiet. To look up.

Theo showed them the sky.

"Hello," he taught them to say to the stars, and slowly, one at a time, the words came out of the other children smooth as anything too. "You're early tonight."

THE END — AND YOUR BEGINNING

The world is full of Theos.

They are the children who line things up, and know everything about one enormous thing, and cover their ears when it all gets too loud. For a long time the world told them that the way their minds worked was a problem to be fixed.

The world was wrong.

Theo did not save the boats by becoming like everyone else. He saved them by being *exactly himself* — by loving the sky so completely, so carefully, in his own quiet way, that when the kingdom needed the sky, he was the only one who still knew it by heart.

If you are a Theo, hold on to this. Your mind is not broken. It is tuned to something the rest of the world got too busy to hear. One day the fog will come, and everyone will be shouting, and you — quiet, careful, looking up — will be the one who knows the way home.

And if you love a Theo: don't ask them to come down off the hill. Climb up. Ask them what the stars are saying.

They have been waiting for someone to ask.

This is a tale from **The Little Rewrites** *— bedtime stories from MK Parrish for children who are learning that they get to write their own happily ever after, exactly as they are. More stories, and the free read-aloud guide for grown-ups,*

are waiting at

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